

Is a Translation Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

8.8

AI EXPOSURE · GENERAL DOCUMENT TRANSLATION
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a translation or interpreting degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study languages" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where translation and interpreting sit in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Language work isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 4.3 to 8.8, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward interpreting, certification and accountable work. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to translation. This field contains both the highest score in the entire index and a genuinely protected career, separated by 4.5 points and the same languages. The languages you already have don't decide which end you land at — the destination does, and the destination is still in front of you. If you're pointed at the exposed end, this guide is about turning the wheel.

The short answer

Not for document translation. Yes for interpreting, and for translation where someone is legally accountable for accuracy.

General document translation scores 8.8 out of 10 — the highest score of any career track in this index. Court and legal interpreting scores 4.3.

Same languages. Same training. A 4.5-point gap, which is the widest internal split we measure anywhere.

And the reason isn't quality. It's consequence — and where you land inside that gap is decided mostly by moves still in front of you.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Court & legal interpreting	3.6	4.0	4.3	+0.7	Low
Medical & healthcare interpreting	3.9	4.3	4.6	+0.7	Moderate
Conference interpreting	4.2	4.6	5.0	+0.8	Moderate
Literary & creative translation	5.0	5.6	6.1	+1.1	Moderate-High
Localization & transcreation	5.6	6.3	6.9	+1.3	Moderate-High
Technical & specialist translation	6.4	7.1	7.6	+1.2	High
General document translation	7.7	8.4	8.8	+1.1	Highest in the index

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, graphic design production scores 8.4, entry-level software development 8.1, and bedside nursing 2.8.

Read the table this way, and note where it starts. General document translation was already at 7.7 in 2023 — before the current wave. This displacement did not begin with generative AI. It largely finished during it. Your job, from here, is to move up the table toward the interpreting and accountable end — not to hope the table moves.

The number that explains everything

One statistic captures this entire guide, and it comes from industry research rather than from us.

73% of enterprises use AI translation internally. Only 19% rely on it for external or regulated communication.

(CSA Research)

That single split is the whole map.

Internal documents, first drafts, comprehension, low-stakes bulk content — automated, at enormous scale, and there is no route back. External communication, regulated content, anything where an error has legal or clinical consequences — still human, and increasingly so.

Now look at the economics, because they explain why the split is so absolute.

	COST
Machine translation APIs	\$10–\$20 per million characters — fractions of a cent per word
Professional human translation	\$0.08–\$0.50 per word
Specialist legal/medical translation	\$0.15–\$0.50 per word
Live interpreting	\$80–\$250 per hour
Conference interpreting	\$600–\$1,200 per day

That is a cost difference of two to three orders of magnitude. No amount of quality advantage survives a gap that size for routine content — which is exactly what the 73% figure describes.

So the survival condition isn't quality. It's consequence.

Human translation persists where the cost of being wrong exceeds the cost of the human by a wide margin: a mistranslated clinical instruction, a contract clause, a court testimony, an immigration document. In those settings the price differential becomes irrelevant, because nobody is optimizing for translation cost when the downside is a misdiagnosis or a wrongful conviction.

The general lesson, and it transfers well beyond languages: when a task becomes nearly free to automate, ask what remains of it. What remains is not the version that was done best — it's the version where someone must be answerable for the result.

Why interpreting holds and translation doesn't

The two are usually spoken of together and they are structurally different jobs.

Translation is text in, text out. Asynchronous, reviewable, correctable, and produced without anyone present. Every one of those properties makes it automatable, and they are properties of the medium rather than of the difficulty.

Interpreting is a person in a room, in real time, under pressure.

- **It's physical and present.** A court interpreter is in the courtroom; a medical interpreter is at the bedside. Presence isn't incidental to the work — in many settings it's legally required.
- **It's real-time and irreversible.** There is no draft, no review, no second pass. The sentence is said and its consequences begin immediately.
- **It carries personal accountability.** A certified court interpreter is answerable for accuracy in a way no system can be, and the certification attaches to a named individual.
- **It handles what text doesn't contain** — tone, hesitation, register, the witness who is frightened, the patient who is minimizing symptoms.

That's why court interpreting scores 4.3 and document translation 8.8 with identical language skills. The languages are the same. Everything structural about the work is different.

The way through isn't to wait for the generalist rung to come back — it isn't coming back. The entry job most language graduates once started on was general document translation, and that is precisely the 8.8. Entering *beside* it is the move: on the interpreting track rather than the translation one, through court or medical certification, with a domain — law, medicine, engineering — paired to the language, or in an in-house regulated role. That's a set of concrete moves, not a hope, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

What the trend shows

General document translation: 7.7 → 8.4 → 8.8. Up 1.1 — from a base that was already the highest in the index.

Court and legal interpreting: 3.6 → 4.0 → 4.3. Up 0.7.

The gap widened from 4.1 points to 4.5. What is distinctive here is the *timing*: most careers in this index show a step change after 2023. Translation was already substantially displaced by then, because text-to-text conversion was the first thing these systems did well. It is the most

mature displacement we measure, and it is the closest thing we have to seeing where other professions end up.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Strong for interpreting	Most durable	Certification attaches to a named person answerable in court.
Regulatory / licensing	Real and strengthening	Durable, and expanding	Language-access law is broadening rather than narrowing.
Physical / embodied	Real for interpreting	Durable	Presence is legally required in many settings.
Judgment under novelty	Moderate	Eroding	Register and nuance resist; standard content does not.

The honest read. Interpreting's protections are genuine and mutually reinforcing — presence, accountability and law. Translation's are almost entirely absent, which is why the score is what it is.

And one protection here is *growing*: compliance obligations around language access — Title VI requirements, healthcare access rules, court accuracy mandates — are expanding, and each one creates demand for accountable human language work.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Translating the document	Post-editing machine output — a different and lower-paid job
Producing first drafts	Reviewing generated drafts
Bulk and repetitive content	Gone, at any professional rate
Terminology research	Automated
Interpreting in a courtroom	Unchanged
Being certified and accountable	Unchanged

One development deserves naming honestly. Machine translation post-editing has become a substantial share of the translation market, and it pays materially less than translation did. It is real work and it is a real career for some people. It is also the clearest example in this index of a profession's core activity being converted into a checking function — the thing we describe as a risk elsewhere, already happened here. If your current work is mostly post-editing, the move is to shift it toward the accountable, real-time and regulated work the score protects.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Real-time interpreting under pressure** — no draft, no review, immediate consequences. The least automatable thing in this profession. 2. **Certified accountability** — being the named person answerable for accuracy in a legal or clinical setting. 3. **Domain expertise** — law, medicine, engineering. The differentiator is increasingly the subject knowledge rather than the language. 4. **Cultural and register judgment** — knowing what a phrase means to this audience, which is the whole of transcreation and much of literary work. 5. **Reading the person** — the hesitation, the evasion, the distress that the words don't carry.

Notably absent: speed, volume and breadth of general vocabulary. These were the traditional markers of a strong translator and are the fastest-depreciating. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: curiosity and adaptability. The languages may be the same across a career, but the tools around them — the CAT platforms, the machine-translation engines, the post-editing workflows — turn over constantly. The linguists who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about their subject and re-tool fastest,

rather than defending the way of working they trained on. In a field this far through its transition, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what the protected end hires for: the trajectory toward accountable, domain-deep work, not the raw translation speed that is depreciating fastest.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The protected end is genuinely well paid and in demand.

- BLS projects roughly **6,900 new interpreter and translator openings a year** through 2034
- Live interpreting runs **\$80–\$250 per hour**; conference interpreting **\$600–\$1,200 per day**; legal interpreting **\$350–\$750 per day**
- Specialist translators (legal, medical, technical) bill **\$60–\$150 per hour** and have **maintained or increased** their rates while generalists face downward pressure
- Prospects are strongest for Portuguese, Mandarin, Korean, Arabic and Spanish — and "particularly strong for interpreters who combine language fluency with domain expertise in law, medicine or technology"

Compliance is a growing tailwind. Language-access requirements in healthcare, courts, education and government are expanding, and each one mandates accountable human provision.

And in-house roles offer stability — government agencies, hospitals and large law firms employ interpreters on salary with benefits and predictable workloads.

What practitioners report as rewarding: being the reason two people can understand each other at a moment that matters; genuine intellectual engagement with language and subject matter; and unusual autonomy for those who freelance well.

What's genuinely hard about it

The generalist market has collapsed and is not coming back. Rates at the floor of the market have reached \$0.05 per word, and machine translation costs fractions of a cent. A career built on general translation competence has no economic foundation left — which is the argument for steering toward interpreting and accountable work sooner rather than later.

Freelancing is the default, with all that implies: income variability, no benefits, and the business of finding clients being a second job.

Interpreting is demanding in ways people underestimate — sustained concentration, emotionally difficult content in medical and legal settings, and no opportunity to correct a mistake.

And certification is essential but fragmented. In the US there is no single government certifying body for translators; court and medical interpreting have their own certification regimes, and requirements vary by state.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Translation and interpreting tend to reward people who:

- **Love languages and something else.** The single most important trait now. Language alone is no longer a career; language plus law, medicine or engineering is.
- **Can hold concentration under pressure** — interpreting is cognitively brutal in bursts
- **Are comfortable with high-stakes accuracy**, where an error has consequences
- **Are self-directed**, because most of this market is freelance
- **Are genuinely interested in people**, not only in text

It's harder for people who want salaried stability (it exists but it is a minority of the market), who are drawn primarily to written translation as a craft (that's the exposed end), who need predictable income early, or who assume that fluency is the qualification — it is the entry ticket. If some of that sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the field; it's a reason to steer toward the parts of it that fit, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

Language-access regulation is expanding, and it is the most reliable source of demand for accountable human language work.

Domain specialization is the whole game. The rate data is unambiguous: generalists face downward pressure, specialists in legal, medical and creative fields have held or increased rates.

And in-house demand is growing in regulated sectors — healthcare systems, courts and government agencies increasingly employ rather than contract, because accountability is easier to manage.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: this profession is further through the transition than any other in this index. The strategic question isn't whether AI will affect it — that's settled — but which version of the work you aim at. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live placement, an interpreting practicum or a first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE LINGUIST LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Aim at accountable work from the start.** Court, medical, immigration, regulated content. Where an error has consequences, the price differential stops mattering.
- 2. Get certified, specifically.** Court interpreting and medical interpreting certifications are the credential that converts language ability into protected work.
- 3. Build genuine domain knowledge.** Legal, medical or technical. This is now the differentiator, and the rate data proves it.
- 4. Understand post-editing honestly.** It is a real market and it pays less than translation did. Knowing that going in is better than discovering it.
- 5. Learn to direct and verify.** For the content that remains human-supervised, the skill is knowing where machine output fails — false fluency, register errors, terminology that is plausible and wrong.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where language skills can lead later

Interpreting across legal, medical, conference and community settings; specialist and certified translation; localization and transcreation; language-access coordination; international policy, diplomacy and development; language teaching; and any commercial role where the language is paired with genuine domain expertise.

The pattern in this index holds with unusual force: the further the work sits from a person in a room and an accountable signature, the higher the exposure. That pattern is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: **almost none of your exposure is fixed yet.** This field is a 4.5-point spread from 4.3 to 8.8, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward interpreting, certification and accountable work.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. Interpreting versus translation is the whole game. A general translation track is the exposed one — general document translation scores 8.8, the highest in this entire index. The protected destinations — court and legal interpreting (4.3), medical and healthcare interpreting (4.6), conference interpreting (5.0) — are reached through the interpreting stream, which is a distinct skill trained differently, not a translation degree with an interpreting module bolted on. If you haven't committed to interpreting, this is the single highest-leverage decision left. If you have, get as much real interpreting practice as the program allows.

2. A domain, while it's still free. Language alone is no longer a career; language plus law, medicine or engineering is. The rate data is unambiguous — specialists in legal, medical and technical work have held or increased rates while generalists face downward pressure. Every module you can still aim at a substantive second subject is a step from the exposed end toward the protected one, and it is far cheaper to acquire now than to bolt on later.

3. Certification, earlier than feels comfortable. Court and medical interpreting certification is the credential that converts fluency into protected work — the named person answerable for accuracy that no system can be. **That certification is the experience that separates the protected end from the exposed floor,** and pursuing it early, rather than treating it as a post-graduation formality, is what puts you on the interpreting curve rather than the post-editing one.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career language titles are also the most exposed.

- **"General translator" and "post-editor" are the 8.8.** They're the default graduate destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at interpreting and regulated translation (4.3, 4.6, 5.0).** More protected, closer to the accountable signature, and driven by language-access law that is expanding rather

than narrowing.

- **Attach to a domain, not "languages in general."** Language paired with law, medicine, technology or a regulated sector inherits that field's protection and its rates. "Any subject, open to anything" aims straight at the exposed end.
- **Chase the in-house seat.** A salaried interpreter role in a hospital, court or government agency — where provision is legally mandated — offers stability and accountable work years sooner than per-word piecework at the market floor.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the years already spent, but you can be the linguist who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — aim at accountable work, get certified, build domain knowledge, understand post-editing honestly, direct and verify — are all available right now, inside a current placement or first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the last: be the person who knows exactly where machine output fails — false fluency, register errors, terminology that is plausible and wrong. In the content that stays human-supervised, that verification skill is the job, and it is the same underlying judgment the accountable, regulated end is built on. You can start building it this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in this field is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree / training — build toward the protected end

- **Treat interpreting and translation as the fork they are.** The protection lives in the interpreting stream (court 4.3, medical 4.6, conference 5.0), not the translation one that runs up to 8.8. Get real interpreting practice — it is a distinct skill, trained differently, and a translation degree with an interpreting module is not it.
- **Pair the language with a domain while it's still free.** Law, medicine or engineering alongside the language is now the differentiator, and it is far cheaper to build in the degree than to bolt on later. Language alone is no longer a career.
- **Point at the certification, not just the diploma.** Court and medical interpreting certification is the credential that converts fluency into protected work — plan the

coursework and the supervised practice around it.

- **Get fluent with machine translation and post-editing as a professional, not a shortcut.** Learn where the output fails — false fluency, register errors, plausible-and-wrong terminology — because verification is the part of the work that survives.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The CAT platforms and MT engines will turn over repeatedly; the linguist who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely curious about the subject, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Vet the in-house regulated routes — health systems, courts, government — and the domain-paired commercial roles before assuming freelancing is the only shape this career takes. The most crowded lane is general document translation, and it is also the most exposed.

During the job hunt — aim, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Court and medical interpreting, conference work, certified and regulated translation, a domain-paired in-house role — not "translator, any subject," which points straight at the 8.8.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** "General translator" and "post-editor" are the automating layer. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An agency still running a large general-translation or post-editing intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut or repriced first once they catch up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Prefer accountability, and the in-house room.** A salaried interpreter seat in a hospital, court or agency — where language access is legally mandated — puts you close to protected, stable work sooner than chasing per-word piecework at the market floor.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around accountable, real-time and regulated work, or around cheaper post-editing throughput, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh the trajectory over the first rate.** A slightly lower-paid seat that builds certification, domain depth and accountable work beats a higher-volume post-editing contract in a lane being repriced underneath you.

Go deeper — further reading

- **[Interpreters and Translators — Occupational Outlook Handbook](#)** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. Projected openings, median pay and entry requirements. Free, and the source of the 6,900 annual openings figure.
- **[American Translators Association](#)** — the professional body, and the route to the credential examination that is most widely recognized in the US market. Worth understanding the certification landscape as you decide where to aim.
- **[Translation rates and pricing, 2026](#)** — the rate data behind the economics above, including the divergence between generalist and specialist rates. Read it for the economics rather than the advice.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 8.8 is that we are scoring a job title that has already changed rather than the work that replaced it.

On this reading, translation didn't disappear — it became post-editing, quality assurance and terminology management, and the volume of content requiring language work has grown enormously as machine translation made multilingual content viable for organisations that could never previously afford it. More content is being translated than at any point in history, and a human is still involved in most of what matters.

There's real support for it: the 73%/19% split shows enterprises using AI internally while keeping humans on anything external, and compliance-driven demand is growing.

Where we land: we think this describes a genuine phenomenon and understates what it costs the practitioner. Post-editing is real work at materially lower rates than translation commanded — the volume grew and the value per unit collapsed. A profession where the work survives at a third of the price is not the same as a profession that survived.

What we're watching: whether specialist and certified rates hold. They have so far, and they are the thing that makes the protected end viable. If they start falling, this guide gets worse rather than better.

Bottom line

Translation contains the most exposed track in this index and a genuinely protected career, and they share a qualification — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

The reason is captured in one statistic: **73% of enterprises use AI translation internally; only 19% rely on it for external or regulated communication.** Everything low-stakes has gone, at a cost difference of two to three orders of magnitude. Everything consequential has stayed.

So the survival condition is not quality — it's consequence. Human language work persists where being wrong has legal or clinical cost, and nowhere else.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Steer toward interpreting rather than translation. Get court or medical certification. Pair the language with law, medicine or engineering, because the rate data shows specialists holding rates while generalists lose theirs. And aim the job hunt at accountable, regulated and in-house work, because a general translation career has no economic floor left.

And one honest thing, if you already love languages. **Nothing here says that's the wrong instinct. It says fluency has stopped being the qualification and become the entry ticket — and that being the person in the room, accountable, when two people absolutely must understand each other, is work that is not going anywhere.** The good news is that everything it takes to get there is still in front of you.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which stream are you on — interpreting or translation — and does it point at *accountability* (the named person answerable in a courtroom or at a bedside) or at *text* (a document produced without anyone present)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. Have you paired the language with a real domain — law, medicine, engineering — or is language still the whole of what you're offering? If it's the latter, what's the nearest way to change that?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected role you could realistically aim for from where you are now — court, medical or conference interpreting — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: how much genuine interpreting practice, versus translation, is still open to you, and is there a reason not to take more? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a protected lane on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing, and check whether any is "general translator" or "post-editor."

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — aim at accountable work, get certified, build domain knowledge, understand post-editing honestly, direct and verify — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a moment where you caught machine output that was fluent and wrong — a register error, plausible-and-wrong terminology? If not, where's the easiest place to start building that skill?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** observe a court or medical interpreter working, if access can be arranged. It's a completely different job from what most people picture, and it's the one the score protects. 10. If the first offer that comes is a general-translation or post-editing role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to accountable, regulated work? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For translation specifically, we've flagged that this is the most mature displacement we measure — the transition largely happened before the current AI wave — and that the surviving work is defined by consequence rather than by quality.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Translation

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

COURT & LEGAL INTERPRETING — 4.3 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.4	7.4	8.0	2.8
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	4.5	0.67
Physical / embodied	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.15
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
				Total	4.3 → 4.3

MEDICAL & HEALTHCARE INTERPRETING — 4.6 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.8	7.8	8.5	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.8	4.2	4.6	0.69
Physical / embodied	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.8	8.8	8.8	0.18
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.2
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.2	8.2	8.2	0.18
				Total	4.6 → 4.6

CONFERENCE INTERPRETING — 5.0 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.3	7.3	8.3	2.91
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.2	4.6	5.0	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.45
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.45
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
				Total	5.01 → 5.0

LITERARY & CREATIVE TRANSLATION — 6.1 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	3.4	4.8	6.0	2.1
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.2	6.8	1.02
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.2
				Total	6.1 → 6.1

LOCALIZATION & TRANSCREATION — 6.9 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.5	6.2	7.6	2.66
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.8	6.5	7.2	1.08
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	6.89 → 6.9

TECHNICAL & SPECIALIST TRANSLATION — 7.6 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.4	8.1	9.3	3.25
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	7.2	7.8	1.17
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.45
				Total	7.6 → 7.6

GENERAL DOCUMENT TRANSLATION — 8.8 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.1	8.8	9.7	3.39
Entry-path erosion	15%	8.0	8.8	9.4	1.41
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	3.0	3.0	3.0	1.05
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
				Total	8.8 → 8.8

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Court & legal interpreting

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	6.4	3.5	0.83	3.6
2025	7.4	4.0	0.83	4.0
Fall 2026	8.0	4.5	0.83	4.3

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.56** and entry-path erosion **+0.15**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.